

Inspection of Darlington Borough Council local authority children's services

Inspection dates: 9 to 13 February 2026

Lead inspector: Gareth Dakin, His Majesty's Inspector

Judgement	Grade
The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families	Outstanding
The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection	Good
The experiences and progress of children in care	Outstanding
The experiences and progress of care leavers	Outstanding
Overall effectiveness	Outstanding

Since the last inspection, senior leaders, supported by strong and unwavering political and corporate commitment, have created an outstanding, ambitious and relational service where children's experiences, safety and aspirations drive every decision. Their clear vision, relentless focus on practice quality and sustained investment in a stable, skilled workforce have embedded a culture where excellent practice for children and families thrives.

Children benefit from timely, well-coordinated help and protection that is both effective and deeply child centred. Practitioners work with families and their networks to secure lasting change. Children in care experience nurturing, stable homes and are surrounded by adults who value them, champion their progress and act with ambition for their futures. Care leavers receive exceptional support that endures as they move into adulthood. They benefit from trusted relationships, clear entitlements and practical and emotional help that gives them confidence, connection and a strong foundation for independence.

Leaders and staff have created the conditions where children, young people and care leavers feel seen, heard and supported, and where their experiences continue to improve because leaders, social workers, practitioners and partners share a deep collective commitment to their safety, wellbeing and success.

What needs to improve?

- The response to children subject to long-term child protection planning and pre-proceedings where neglect is a feature. (outcome 1, national framework)

The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection: good

1. Children and families in Darlington benefit from timely, well-coordinated and effective support from a wide range of early help services. Strong partnership working and a coherent early help offer enhance the quality of assessments and interventions. Purposeful direct work with children and their families informs clear analysis and planning, leading to strengthened parental capacity and improved wellbeing for children. Effective broader professional involvement is ensuring that children's needs are identified and addressed earlier.
2. The Children's Initial Advice Team (CIAT) provides a proportionate, consistent and child-focused response to safeguarding concerns. Professionals across agencies have a strong understanding of intervention thresholds, and experienced practitioners use relational practice to establish early, trusting connections with families. This ensures a comprehensive understanding of each child's lived experience and supports balanced, well-reasoned decision-making. When statutory services are required, clear recommendations help children receive the right support at the right time.
3. Social workers in the CIAT demonstrate a clear understanding of how historical events and trauma affect children. Domestic abuse concerns are managed effectively through multi-agency triage with police, health, education and social care partners. Social workers show strong professional curiosity and a well-developed grasp of the risks to children living with domestic abuse, enabling them to assess risk and family dynamics thoroughly.
4. In line with national reforms, a pilot team, led by an experienced social work manager and supported by alternatively qualified staff, provides children and families with timely, well-considered and compassionate support. Working alongside Assessment and Safeguarding Teams, they undertake comprehensive assessments that are thorough and firmly rooted in the child's experience. Through meaningful direct work, practitioners build trusting relationships that help children and their families feel understood and help families make positive and lasting changes.

5. When a safeguarding response is required, strategy meetings are convened promptly and are well attended by police and other key agencies. Child protection enquiries are thorough. They are supported by strong information-sharing. When children are at risk of significant harm, strategy meetings result in coordinated actions that keep the child's risks, needs and voice central to decision-making. The emergency duty team is effective and ensures that children are helped and better safeguarded out of hours.
6. When child protection conferences are required, these are timely and result in effective information-sharing forums, which involve parents and children's extended family members. Partner agencies consistently engage and contribute to coordinated multi-agency planning that is child centred and needs-led. Conference chairs oversee and review child protection plans effectively.
7. Social work assessments of children's needs are of consistently high quality. They are detailed, analytical and clearly informed by the child's voice. Children's unique needs are recognised and risks are well identified, with family history thoroughly explored by professionally curious practitioners who engage family networks in safety planning.
8. Management oversight provides objective review of assessment quality, recommendations and next steps. Practitioners integrate multi-agency information effectively and draw on both current and historical concerns to produce balanced, well-reasoned analysis. Children and families receive help and intervention during the assessment phase, which helps to improve situations for children and, in some instances, helps to reduce the need for longer-term support.
9. Most children's plans are developed collaboratively with children and their families. Practitioners use relational practice to create clear, needs-led actions. Regular core groups and planning meetings support effective review of progress. Strengthened managerial oversight since the last inspection is effective in monitoring how plans are progressing. However, for a small number of children, variability remains in how managers and child protection conference chairs record their challenge, guidance and direction to staff and ensure that plans for children make timely progress.
10. Most children in the pre-proceedings stage of the Public Law Outline (PLO) benefit from timely, well-managed interventions. Specialist assessments and family involvement are prioritised, with creative packages of support often enabling children to remain safely at home. A small number of children experience repeated and prolonged interventions, particularly when cumulative neglect is a concern, resulting in slower decision-making and an overoptimistic view of progress.
11. Children at risk of exploitation benefit from strong systems for early identification, information-sharing and coordinated action. Practitioners work persistently and at the child's pace, using trauma-informed approaches to

reduce risk. Mapping work strengthens intelligence-sharing across agencies, which is helping build a fuller picture of children's experiences.

12. The response to children who go missing is effective and well-coordinated. Return home interviews are offered promptly, and more children are taking up the offer. This is supporting a better understanding of triggers and risk. Strong multi-agency collaboration between police, exploitation services and other professionals supports well-informed, risk-led decisions to reduce risk and make children safer.
13. The identification of children who are young carers is developing. Leaders have initiatives in place to help practitioners better understand young carers, their caring status and how their associated needs are being responded to, but it is too soon to see the impact of this for children.
14. Children are supported to remain at home or within their family and friends network when it is safe to do so. The Keeping Families Together team provides bespoke practical and emotional family support to help achieve this, using a sensitive approach that explores safety, risk and need.
15. The local authority designated officer (LADO) provides a prompt and robust response to allegations against adults working with children. Thorough screening, clear and consistently applied thresholds and well-attended allegations management meetings support safe, well-reasoned decision-making. The LADO continues to strengthen local links with partners and increase awareness of the role. This has led to an increase in more consultations and referrals, contributing to more effective safeguarding practice.
16. Leaders are skilled in ensuring that children are in receipt of a suitable education. When children are missing from education, the use of effective procedures and processes enables leaders to locate children as quickly as possible.

The experiences and progress of children in care: outstanding

17. The experiences and progress of children in care in Darlington have further improved since the last inspection. Children in care experience nurturing, stable relationships with their workers and their carers that enable them to feel valued, understood and ambitious for their futures. A relational culture is deeply embedded across the service and consistently shapes day-to-day practice with children in care and their families.
18. When children cannot live safely at home, most children come into care at the right time and for the right reasons. Early permanence is prioritised by social workers. Timely, well-informed decisions are helping children to secure the stable, loving relationships they need to grow and thrive. Social workers act with purpose and clarity from the earliest stages of care planning, ensuring that children's needs and experiences shape every decision. Children's wider family

networks are engaged whenever possible to secure safe and lasting permanence at the earliest opportunity when children cannot remain safely with their parents. This approach ensures that children are supported to stay connected with, or living with, the people they know best while assessments and decision-making remain focused on their safety, stability and long-term wellbeing.

19. Children's plans reflect their unique identities, their lived histories, strengths and aspirations. Needs and risks to children are understood and managed very effectively. Social workers adapt plans quickly when children's needs change and are highly attuned to these. Planning is purposeful and timely, with children's views actively shaping decisions and improving their experiences. Professionals share a clear understanding of each child's needs and work together with a unified sense of purpose to ensure that decisions are well informed and child centred.
20. Children's plans are written with the child in mind, with their needs, experiences and aspirations at the centre. Plans are reviewed effectively by independent reviewing officers (IROs) who provide meaningful oversight of children's progress. IROs maintain regular contact with children and their social workers between reviews, enabling them to track progress, challenge delays and ensure that plans remain focused on what matters most to each child. This consistent involvement helps children attend their reviews, express their views and influence decisions about their lives, strengthening both the quality and impact of their care.
21. Social workers see their children regularly and undertake purposeful interventions through direct work and multi-agency planning. A very small number of children have experienced changes in their social worker, and as a result, they find it a challenge to form a relationship of trust with their social workers.
22. A strong emphasis is placed on the importance of children's family networks. These are explored with curiosity and respect, and when it is safe and appropriate, children are helped to maintain positive relationships with their family and friends networks. This is supporting many children to better understand their identity and their experiences and remain connected to and live with people who are important to them.
23. Since the last inspection, there has been a clear and sustained focus on expanding and improving the range of high-quality homes for children in care. Most children live in stable, suitable homes. This includes well-matched residential homes where children experience nurturing, stable relationships and consistent oversight from social workers who know them well and respond to their needs with consistency and care. This relational approach is making a tangible difference to children's sense of safety, belonging and progress.

24. A very small number of children, in exceptional circumstances, live in unlawful provision when no other suitable options are immediately available. These arrangements are subject to rigorous senior management oversight and close social worker involvement to ensure that children's safety, wellbeing and day-to-day experiences are closely monitored. Leaders act with urgency to secure registered homes as soon as possible. This strong oversight, combined with a clear focus on children's needs and rights, is tightly controlled, time limited and centred on securing the most suitable home for each child.
25. Disabled children in care and those with additional vulnerabilities are well supported by skilled social workers who have specialist knowledge and a strong understanding of how each child's needs shape their daily experiences. This expertise enables workers to build trusting relationships with children, communicate effectively and tailor their support so that children feel understood and included and experience care that is responsive, respectful and ambitious for their futures.
26. Unaccompanied asylum-seeking children live in homes that meet their needs. Their cultural, linguistic and religious identities are carefully considered and are clearly reflected in their plans. Social workers build trusting relationships, act as advocates and ensure that each child's individual needs are met. Support includes practical help with accommodation, healthcare, education and the asylum process, alongside consistent emotional and psychological support.
27. Children who are at risk of exploitation benefit from effective multi-agency information-sharing and planning. Children who go missing are offered return home interviews, which explore their reasons for going missing. This informs risk management and future planning. This results in children being more able to share critical information about their experiences that workers then use to safety plan and reduce risk.
28. There are many opportunities for children to contribute to the development of children's services. Strong and effective relationships between the local authority and children ensure that their voice and influence is heard and represented through targeted activities and group work. The views of children in care have influenced meaningful service developments, and the impact of their voice and influence is visible locally, nationally and internationally, with recent notable contributions of children in care to the Youth Parliament and the International Youth Conference. Leaders continue to strengthen the corporate parenting panel so that it remains relevant and continues to benefit children in care and care leavers.
29. Children are encouraged to engage in social and recreational activities outside school which promote their wellbeing. Children who spoke to inspectors said they are happy and safe where they live, they know their IRO and see their social worker regularly. Children were aware of their care plan.

30. The health of children in care is a shared responsibility that sits at the heart of corporate parenting. Social workers, partners and carers understand children's physical, emotional and development health needs. They ensure that health assessments are timely and thorough and lead to meaningful action.
31. An increasing number of children are returning safely to their families supported by wider reforms that promote the use of family and friends networks. Children leave care for the right reasons, supported by clear assessments. Strong, independent oversight and careful decision-making prioritise their safety, stability and long-term futures. When children are reunified with their parents, these decisions are underpinned by robust assessments. Close oversight by managers ensures that the issues which led to their care have been addressed, and that improvements can be sustained.
32. More children are achieving permanence within their kinship networks through special guardianship orders strengthened by effective financial support and tailored packages of help. Together, these developments ensure that children's exit from care is well informed, well supported and centred on securing safe, lasting relationships within their families and communities.
33. The fostering service has strengthened significantly since the last inspection. There is a clear focus on securing stability for children through high-quality training and support for foster carers and well-matched placements. Foster carers benefit from a comprehensive learning offer, including specialist therapeutic approaches which equip them to understand children's needs and provide nurturing, consistent care. Most foster carers speak positively about the advice and support they receive, reflecting a culture of strong professional relationships and responsive practice. Clear recruitment targets are widening the pool of potential carers, while timely, well-considered assessments of foster carers and connected carers have increased the availability of local homes. This has reduced unplanned moves and improved placement stability, ensuring more children are experiencing the security and continuity they need.
34. Darlington is a member of a Regional Adoption Agency (Adoption Tees Valley). Children benefit from an effective adoption service. The assessment of prospective adopters is thorough and detailed, and post-adoption support is effective. Strong connectivity and governance between services in Darlington and Adoption Tees Valley has resulted in more children benefiting from stable, secure homes.
35. Before children turn 18, transitions to greater independence are well coordinated and at a pace appropriate to each young person's needs. Social workers demonstrate a strong understanding of entitlements, and practical and emotional preparation for leaving care is embedded through consistent and tailored direct work. Pathway plans are updated promptly and clearly outline strengths and worries. Children are more prepared for leaving care as a result, and this is improving their progress and experiences.

36. The virtual school works effectively with schools and other settings to ensure that children in care benefit from a positive education experience. There is a shared aspiration that children in care will do well. This results in children in care who are well supported through their academic and pastoral offer to make progress from their starting points. The virtual school quickly intervenes if children in care need additional support and/or guidance. This work is always bespoke to the child and welcomed by schools. The virtual school plans effectively for children in care to be successful when they move on to post-16 pathways. This enables children in care and care leavers to be engaged in education, employment and training more effectively.

The experiences and progress of care leavers: outstanding

37. Care leavers in Darlington benefit from a strong and purposeful offer that reflects a deep understanding of their starting points, their vulnerabilities and the impact of their adverse childhood experiences. They benefit from support from adults whom they know and trust and who have ambition for them. The support available to care leavers is practical, relational and enduring.
38. Personal advisers (PAs) in the leaving care service become actively involved with children in care before they transfer into the service. This is ensuring that trusting relationships are built early and that planning for adulthood is thoughtful, steady and centred on each young person's needs. This early relational approach helps young people feel known, supported and confident as they move towards independence. It ensures that decisions about their future are grounded in a strong understanding of their strengths, aspirations and safety.
39. An 'always here' model of practice in the care leavers service ensures that the care and support continue well beyond a young person's formal care leaver status. The persistence and enthusiasm of PAs in maintaining proactive and purposeful contact with care leavers and their families is resulting in high keeping-in-touch rates. This is encouraging more care leavers to maintain contact with the service.
40. The council's investment in care leavers up to the age of 25 and beyond is quite exceptional. The level of emotional presence, persistence and advocacy offered by PAs mirrors what an excellent parent would do. This includes sensitive and proactive support provided to the most vulnerable young people, including young parents who are helped to feel safe, valued and never alone in navigating early adulthood and parenthood. Links with community partners and local businesses are providing care leavers with support and help at a community level, creating a deeper understanding of their needs and how these can be met.

41. Pathway plans are clear and purposeful and firmly centred on each young person's needs, giving care leavers a strong understanding of the support available to them to help plan for their futures. Care leavers have a clear understanding of their entitlements and are making good use of the local offer. Many are benefiting from support such as council tax reduction, funded driving lessons and tests, free gym memberships and bus passes. When care leavers do not live in Darlington, these entitlements are made to mirror the offer wherever they live, ensuring they are not disadvantaged by living elsewhere.
42. Care leavers benefit from a centrally located 'hub' that offers a warm, welcoming and easily accessible space where young people feel known, valued and supported. Its relational environment encourages care leavers, including those well into adulthood, to drop in for connection, advice or simply to say hello. This reflects the trust and sense of belonging it creates. Others access the hub at times of need for emotional and practical support, knowing they will be met with understanding and help. This consistent bond is a vital anchor for young people as they navigate independence, offering stability, community and a place where they are always welcomed.
43. Most care leavers live in suitable accommodation. The range of housing options for care leavers, supported by joint assessment between children's services and housing, ensures that young people move into accommodation that is well matched to their individual needs. As a result, nearly all care leavers live in safe, stable and suitable homes that support their growing independence.
44. When possible, options around 'staying put' are considered, which is allowing some to remain with carers whom they feel comfortable with and know well. For others, post-18 support is tailored to their needs and support is provided in line with this. For example, an established 'staying close' provision is providing some vulnerable care leavers with enhanced help and support to help them to develop the skills they need to successfully have their own tenancy. Care leavers told us that they feel safe where they live and value the relationships they have built and the strong support they get.
45. A powerful initiative enables care leavers to act as peer mentors for other children in care, using their lived experience to guide, encourage and inspire the next generation of care leavers. This approach strengthens children's sense of belonging and hope while giving care leavers a meaningful role in shaping the system they grew up in. Their insight helps younger children feel understood and supported, and it reinforces a culture where experience is valued, voices are heard and young people actively contribute to better outcomes for others.
46. A strong culture of participation in the leaving care service is helping care leavers to feel listened to and shape services locally and regionally. Their involvement in the Corporate Parenting Board, developments in the local offer, participation locally, regionally and nationally and membership of interview panels reflect the value placed on their contributions.

47. Former unaccompanied asylum-seeking children who are now care leavers receive thoughtful, proactive support that helps them work towards their goals and succeed in education and training. Their identity needs are recognised, respected and well supported. PAs understand the importance of stability for these young people and respond with sensitivity and insight, remaining alert to their vulnerabilities, including any risks of harm.
48. Care leavers who are pregnant or are young parents receive sensitive, well-coordinated support that reflects a strong understanding of their individual needs. PAs work closely with them, providing practical guidance on childcare and housing, while helping them manage the emotional realities of early parenthood.
49. Care leavers in custody are well supported by their PAs, who maintain regular contact and provide persistent practical and emotional help. Strong links with services ensure that plans for release are coordinated and that the right support is in place to help young people settle safely back into the community.

The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families: outstanding

50. Since the last inspection in 2022, senior leaders have continued to strengthen and refine practice across the borough, creating an outstanding service. Deeply embedded, child-centred and relational practice is unmistakable at every level. The culture is defined by a shared belief in the worth, potential and voice of children and care leavers, and a workforce that understands what they must do, why it matters, and how their actions change children's lives.
51. Political and corporate support is strong, stable and highly committed to improving the experience of children and families in Darlington. The lead member provides rigorous oversight, clear political accountability and visible advocacy for children's services. The new chief executive has a confident grasp of both the progress achieved and the challenges ahead and is assured in the direction and leadership of children's social care. The executive director for people has built a strong, effective and strategically focused leadership team that provides consistent direction and oversight. By modelling relational practice as the cornerstone of their approach, senior leaders have created a culture in which children in need of help and protection, children in care and care leavers are consistently valued and receive the support, care and opportunities they need to thrive.
52. Professional relationships across key partners remain strong, mature and purposeful, with shared accountability for the experience and progress of children and care leavers. The partnership understands local needs and defines its shared priorities around these.

53. Senior leaders are outward looking and consistently focused on improvement. They have a strong track record of responding effectively to areas for development, new demands and emerging challenges, ensuring that the service continues to evolve in ways that benefit children, their families and care leavers.
54. Innovation is approached with care, discipline and attention to positive impact. Leaders have taken a steady and thoughtful approach to the children's social care reforms. They are developing, piloting and testing new ways of working to ensure that change is sustainable in practice, and can deliver real improvements for families before it is embedded. Leaders also recognise the importance of bringing partners with them through the reforms. By shaping developments collaboratively, they strengthen collective ownership and increase the impact of change across the wider partnership. This deliberate, reflective and personal approach ensures that long-term impact for children and families remains at the heart of every decision.
55. The self-evaluation provided by the leaders is accurate, reflective and aligned with the findings of this inspection. It demonstrates a leadership team supported by a strong quality assurance framework and robust data analysis. This is enabling them to understand the quality of practice and children's lived experiences with precision. This insight is used purposefully to shape priorities and drive continuous improvement. Leaders draw on feedback from children, families and partner agencies to refine services and ensure that developments are focused on what will make the greatest difference for children. As a result, future service design is informed, targeted and ambitious, ensuring that children's experiences continue to improve from an already strong base.
56. Throughout this inspection, it has been evident that the council's sense of responsibility and accountability as a corporate parent and corporate grandparent is a strategic priority. This is demonstrated through sustained and thoughtful investment in the services that matter most to children. The fostering service has been strengthened, and increased capacity in local children's homes has expanded high-quality local options, keeping children closer to their community.
57. The council's decision to keep the care leavers hub located in the town centre further reflects the depth of its commitment. By safeguarding this accessible, welcoming space, political leaders have shown how much they value their care leavers and the relationships that sustain them into adulthood. This commitment is reinforced by mature, purposeful multi-agency collaboration across the borough. Partners work together with clarity and shared accountability, ensuring that children in care and care leavers experience coordinated support, consistent opportunities and adults who collectively act in their best interests.
58. Since the last inspection, there has been considerable investment in the workforce, ensuring that more children benefit from consistent, skilled and

relationship-based practice. This targeted investment has stabilised teams and enabled social workers to spend more time on direct work with children, although some unavoidable workforce pressures remain. This has resulted in a small number of children experiencing a change of social worker. Leaders have taken decisive action in stabilising the workforce to address this and mitigate the impact for children.

59. Inspectors found a resilient and committed workforce with strong morale and a shared commitment to improving children's lives. Some staff told inspectors how much they love working in Darlington. Staff value the high level of support they receive, including creative development opportunities and initiatives such as the experts in practice programme, which has positively influenced practice and reflects leaders' ambition for continuous professional growth. The improvements in the quality of supervision since the last inspection are notable. Workloads, while still high for some staff, are reducing and are actively monitored to ensure that practitioners can maintain high-quality, child-centred direct work.
60. This sustained focus on workforce development ensures that children and families experience skilled, reflective practitioners whose work is consistently aligned with the organisation's relational values, and ambition for outstanding experiences for children, their families and for care leavers.

The Office for Standards in Education, Children's Services and Skills (Ofsted) regulates and inspects to achieve excellence in the care of children and young people, and in education and skills for learners of all ages. It regulates and inspects childcare and children's social care, and inspects the Children and Family Court Advisory and Support Service (Cafcass), schools, colleges, initial teacher training, further education and skills, adult and community learning, and education and training in prisons and other secure establishments. It assesses council children's services, and inspects services for children looked after, safeguarding and child protection.

If you would like a copy of this document in a different format, such as large print or Braille, please telephone 0300 123 1231, or email enquiries@ofsted.gov.uk.

You may reuse this information (not including logos) free of charge in any format or medium, under the terms of the Open Government Licence. To view this licence, visit www.nationalarchives.gov.uk/doc/open-government-licence, write to the Information Policy Team, The National Archives, Kew, London TW9 4DU, or email: psi@nationalarchives.gsi.gov.uk.

This report is available at <https://reports.ofsted.gov.uk/>.

Interested in our work? You can subscribe to our monthly newsletter for more information and updates: <http://eepurl.com/iTrDn>.

Piccadilly Gate
Store Street
Manchester
M1 2WD

T: 0300 123 1231
Textphone: 0161 618 8524
E: enquiries@ofsted.gov.uk
W: www.gov.uk/ofsted

© Crown copyright 2026